

Interview transcript – travel insurance user journey

Interviewer: Thanks for speaking with me today. Could you introduce yourself and walk me through your recent trip and how travel insurance played a role?

Participant (John Doe): Yeah, sure. I'll just go through it as it happened because my feelings about it really changed along the way.

At the start, when I was getting ready for the trip, I was comparing destinations, checking visas, looking into vaccines, thinking about risks, and then trying to pick travel insurance. I read through a bunch of policies and tried to understand what's actually covered, especially medical stuff, but honestly I felt a bit overwhelmed and not very confident in my choice.

The main problem was that everything was written in this super dense, almost legal language, so even after reading it I still wasn't sure what I was buying. Different companies described the same things differently, which made comparing them confusing, and there wasn't really any help figuring out what level of cover I actually needed. It would've helped a lot if they just explained things in plain English, maybe showed a few real examples like "this is what happens if you break your leg", or even guided me based on where I'm going and what I'm planning to do, instead of just dumping a generic policy on me.

When I moved on to booking, I booked flights, hotels, some tours, and then bought the insurance by filling in all my trip details, picking a plan, adding extras, and paying. I did feel a bit relieved afterwards, like okay, that's sorted, but still not 100% sure I picked the right options.

The process itself was kind of annoying because I had to enter the same info multiple times, and it wasn't really clear what those add-ons actually changed. After paying, I just got this long PDF, which didn't really help me understand what I bought in a simple way. It would be so much better if it just pulled info from my bookings automatically and showed me a clear summary, like a dashboard, instead of a wall of text, and actually explained what difference each option makes.

During the flight part, I checked in, went through the airport, boarded, and flew out. Everything went fine, so I felt pretty calm, maybe slightly reassured knowing I had insurance, but I didn't really interact with it at all.

Looking back, though, it didn't really help me in any practical way. Like, if something did go wrong, I wouldn't have known what to do straight away. The app didn't show anything useful at the right time, and I wasn't even sure I could quickly show proof of insurance without internet. It would be way better if it just recognised where I am in the journey and surfaced the right stuff, like delays, baggage issues, emergency contacts, and especially made key things available offline so you're not stuck when you need it.

When I got to the hotel, everything was great. I checked in, settled in, explored a bit, used the facilities, and just relaxed. I felt really good at that point, like properly on holiday, and didn't think about insurance at all.

But at the same time, it kind of disappeared completely. It didn't give me anything useful like nearby hospitals or emergency info, which would've actually been good to know just in case. I had to look everything up myself. It would be nice if the app just gave you a bit of local context, like "here's the nearest clinic" or "here's what to do if something happens here", so it feels like it's actually supporting you, not just sitting there unused.

The island tour was honestly one of the best parts. I booked a local tour, went over to the island, did some snorkelling and walking around, just enjoyed the whole day. I felt really excited and didn't really think about risks at the time.

But later I realised I had no idea if those activities were even covered. There was no easy way to check that on the spot, and no guidance about risks or what I should be aware of. It would've been really helpful if the app just told me "yep, this is covered" or "this isn't", and maybe gave a few quick tips or even said what I should document if something goes wrong, because at the time you're not thinking about that at all.

Then I had the accident – I slipped and hurt my leg, and everything suddenly became stressful and confusing. I was trying to deal with the pain, figure out what to do, who to call, where to go, and I felt pretty anxious and overwhelmed.

The worst part was that I couldn't even easily show proof of insurance because the app needed internet, which I didn't have. I also didn't know which hospital to go to or if it would be covered, and it wasn't clear whether I should call the insurer first or just go straight for treatment. In that moment, you just need really simple, clear guidance, like an emergency mode that tells you exactly what to do, gives you offline access to your details, and maybe even points you to the nearest approved hospital or lets you contact support in one tap.

At the hospital, I checked in, explained everything, got treated, and dealt with paperwork and payments while trying to contact the insurer. It was pretty frustrating and stressful, especially not knowing what I'd get reimbursed for.

They asked for proof of insurance, but what I had wasn't really usable, and there were language and process barriers as well. I ended up paying upfront because I wasn't sure what else to do, and the insurer wasn't immediately helpful when I needed them. It would make a huge difference if there was a simple, clear proof of insurance that hospitals recognise, and if the insurer could actually communicate directly with them. Even just guidance like "pay this, don't pay that" in real time would take a lot of stress out of it.

Once I got back home, I started the claim by collecting documents, filling out forms, uploading receipts, and then just waiting. This part felt slow and quite frustrating, especially after everything else.

It was very manual, and I wasn't always sure what exactly they needed from me, so I had to redo things a few times. Updates were slow, and I had to chase them to find out what was happening. It would be so much better if the claim was partially pre-filled based on what already happened, with a clear checklist of what's needed, and some kind of tracker showing progress. Just having clearer communication would already make it feel less painful.

Interviewer: That's really helpful. If you had to sum it up, what stands out?

Participant (John Doe): It just feels disconnected from the actual trip. When everything is fine, it does nothing, and when something goes wrong, it's hard to use. If it was more integrated and actually helped you along the way, especially in stressful moments, it would feel like real support instead of just something you bought and hoped you wouldn't need.